

The Salem witch trials

In the conservative, closed-in society of 17th-century New England, accusations of witchcraft were often directed at those not adhering to the teachings of the Puritan church. In 1692, the village of Salem in Massachusetts was isolated and prone to factional disagreements between families. When Betty, the nine-year-old daughter of the new Puritan pastor Samuel Parris, and her cousin Abigail began to experience strange convulsions, suspicions of dark magic arose immediately. The doctor found no physical cause, so magistrates were called in. Under interrogation, Betty and Abigail identified the pastor's slave Tituba and two other women as having caused their affliction. Soon the web of accusations spread, as Tituba confessed that she had consorted with Satan's familiars and signed a "Devil's book," in which the names of other local women appeared.

Other girls began to show symptoms and panic gripped the village. A trial was convened in May but the admission of "spectral evidence"—witness testimony that the spirit of the accused tormented them in a dream or vision—made defense difficult. By October, 19 people had been hanged, including respected members of the community. When accusations of witchcraft touched even Governor Phips's wife, the authorities stepped in. Spectral evidence was excluded from trials and only three more people were condemned, all later reprieved. The Salem witch trials left a lasting scar on the colony, and in 1702 the General Court of Massachusetts declared that they had been unlawful.

"I am as innocent as
the child unborn."

BRIDGET BISHOP, EXECUTED FOR WITCHCRAFT AT SALEM, 1692

